

whole sequence of events, both Godhra-related and post-Godhra. He concluded his speech by saying, "Nevertheless, as the head of the government I take responsibility for what has happened. I am ready to tender my resignation."

The moment Modi said that the meeting hall reverberated with a thunderous response from the hundred-odd members of the party's top decision-making body and special invitees: "*Isteepha mat do, isteepha mat do.*" (Don't resign, don't resign). I then ascertained the views of senior leaders of the party on this matter. Each one of them, without exception, said, "No, he must not resign."

Thus, ended the debate inside the party on an issue that had deeply divided opinions in Indian society and polity. While the party's decision in Goa did displease many people in the country, it is equally true that it was in line with the wishes of a much larger section of our society.

Politics often entails making difficult choices. The difficulty lies in the very complexity of the issues and situations that one is called upon to deal with. A tough choice is sometimes an unpalatable one. But I believe that, when one is convinced about the rightness of one's decision, one must not hesitate to stand by it. History has indeed vindicated the party's decision not to ask Modi to resign.

■ GUJARAT RIOTS

Of the many interventions to save innocent lives that I made during that distressing period of communal bloodletting in Gujarat, I shall recall two here.

One day I received a call from Najma Heptulla, deputy chairperson of the Rajya Sabha. "Akbar, my husband, wants to talk to you urgently about an sos from some Muslim merchants in Ahmedabad," she said. Akbar told me that the traders of Bohra Bazaar had approached him to urgently contact someone in the government to save them from an imminent attack from armed men in a nearby Hindu *basti*. I immediately rang up Chief Minister Modi and asked him to take necessary steps to provide protection to the needy. Modi called me back the next day to say that no untoward incident took place and potential miscreants were arrested. After the return of normalcy, a delegation of traders from Bohra Bazaar, along with Akbar, met me in Delhi to express their appreciation and gratitude for the timely steps taken by the Central and state governments.

In another such incident, I received a call one day from Somnath Chatterjee. "Advaniji, I want to speak to you about an urgent matter," he said in a tone that immediately con-

44 IN ONE OF MY SUBSEQUENT VISITS TO BHAVNAGAR
local CPI(M) activists and some maulvis called on me and expressed their thanks. "We only did our duty", I told them. **77**



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